

MONUMENTS WITH EXPLANATIONS IN ARLINGTON NATIONAL CEMETARY

WHILE NOT ALL OF THE MONUMENTS ARE NOT SHOWN THIS CAN BE A TOUR FOR THOSE WHO HAVE NOT VISITED ARLINGTON OR A REVIEW FOR THOSE WHO HAVE.

A LONG ARTICLE WITH A LOT OF HISTORY

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APOLLO ONE CREW



Dedicated on June 2, 2022, the Apollo 1 Monument commemorates the crew of the first Apollo mission. Command Pilot Virgil "Gus" Grissom, Senior Pilot Edward H. White II, and Pilot Roger B. Chaffee died on January 27, 1967, when a fire swept through the command module during a pre-launch test. The Apollo 1 mission, scheduled to launch on February 21, 1967, would have been the first human-crewed Apollo flight.

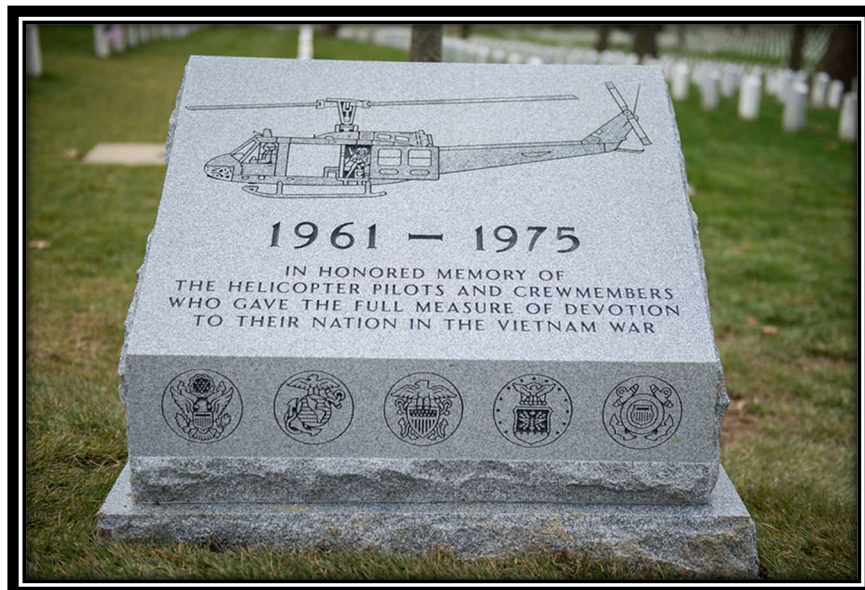
Approved in the 2018 National Defense Authorization Act, the monument was sponsored by the Aerospace Industries Association (AIA) and the Challenger Center.

It received support from members of Congress, NASA (whose administrator, Bill Nelson, attended the dedication), the astronauts' families, and the aerospace community. At the dedication, AIA's president and CEO stated, "Our success in space is a tribute to Gus Grissom, Ed White, and Roger Chaffee. Their sacrifice paved the way for the achievements of America's space program."

As requested by the astronauts' families, the granite monument features a Latin inscription, "Ad Astra per Aspera," which translates to, "A rough road leads to the stars." Its location in Section 3 is a short walk from the [Challenger](#) and [Columbia](#) Memorials, which honor the crews of the two space shuttles.

Apollo 1 astronauts [Gus Grissom and Roger Chaffee](#) also have individual gravesites in Section 3. Ed White is buried at West Point Cemetery in West Point, New York.

VIETNAM HELICOPTER PILOTS



This monument (dedicated on April 18, 2018) and memorial tree (dedicated on August 28, 2015) honor the helicopter pilots and crew members who died while serving in Southeast Asia from 1961 to 1975.

Vietnam has been called America's "Helicopter War" because helicopters provided mobility throughout the war zone, facilitating rapid troop transport, close air support, resupply, medical evacuation, reconnaissance, and search and rescue capabilities.

The Vietnam Helicopter Pilots Association (VHPA) estimates that over 100,000 helicopter pilots and crew members served during the Vietnam War. Over 4,800 helicopter pilots and crew members were killed in action, and more than 300 are buried at Arlington National Cemetery. In addition, Arlington National Cemetery is the final resting place of helicopter crews whose remains were recovered many years after the end of the Vietnam War.

UH-1N Iroquois helicopters flew over the Memorial Amphitheater and the memorial tree during the Vietnam Helicopter Pilots Association Living Tree Memorial dedication ceremony at Arlington National Cemetery on August 28, 2015.

The memorial tree, planted earlier, was dedicated to honor those helicopter pilots and crew members who were killed during the Vietnam War. It is a red maple (*Acer rubrum*) native to the United States.

BATTLE OF THE BULGE MEMORIAL



The Battle of the Bulge, described by Winston Churchill as "undoubtedly the greatest American battle" of World War II, took place in the Ardennes Forest region of Belgium and Luxembourg from December 16, 1944 to January 25, 1945.

The last major German counteroffensive on the Western Front ended in victory for Allied forces under the command of General Dwight D. Eisenhower — but at great cost.

Soldiers fought in brutal winter conditions, and the U.S. Army lost approximately 19,000 men (and suffered some 75,000 total casualties) **in what became the United States' deadliest single World War II battle.**

In 2002, Congress authorized the placement in Arlington National Cemetery of a memorial honoring World War II veterans of the Battle of the Bulge. The memorial was dedicated on May 8, 2006, in a ceremony attended by 300 veterans and family members, along with Prime Minister Guy Verhofstadt of Belgium and Luxembourg's secretary of state for culture, Octavie Modert. Its main inscription reads, "To World War II American soldiers who fought in the Battle of the Bulge — the greatest land battle in the history of the United States Army." Text on the base of the memorial reads, "Triumph of courage" and "From the grateful people of the Kingdom of Belgium and Grand Duchy of Luxembourg."

THE UNKNOWN SOLDIERS OF THE CIVIL WAR

Near Arlington House, in what was once part of the estate's famous rose garden, stands a monument dedicated to the unknown soldiers who died in the Civil War. The monument, dedicated in September 1866, stands atop a masonry vault containing the remains of 2,111 soldiers gathered from the fields of Bull Run (Manassas, VA) and the route to the Rappahannock River. The remains were found scattered across the battlefields or in trenches within an approximately 25-mile radius of Washington, D.C.

Nearly 1,800 remains came from Bull Run alone.



The mass carnage of the Civil War had quickly overwhelmed the capacity of existing cemeteries — especially in northern Virginia, where many of the war's early battles were fought. As Union officials looked for a solution to this problem, U.S. Army Quartermaster General Montgomery Meigs proposed that the Arlington House property, which the Army had occupied since May 1861, could be used as a burial ground.

This was the first memorial at Arlington to be dedicated to soldiers who had died in battle and whose remains could not be identified. The vault likely contains the remains of Confederate soldiers as well as U.S. Army troops.

The side of the memorial features this inscription:

BENEATH THIS STONE REPOSE THE BONES OF TWO THOUSAND HUNDRED ELEVEN UNKNOWN SOLDIERS GATHERED AFTER THE WAR FROM THE FIELDS OF BULL RUN, AND THE ROUTE TO THE RAPPAHANOCK, THEIR REMAINS COULD NOT BE IDENTIFIED. BUT THEIR NAMES AND DEATHS ARE RECORDED IN THE ARCHIVES OF THEIR COUNTRY, AND ITS GRATEFUL CITIZENS THEM AS OF THEIR NOBLE ARMY OF MARTYRS. MAY THEY REST IN PEACE. SEPTEMBER. A. D. 1866

IRAN RESCUE MISSION

The Iran Rescue Mission Memorial commemorates the role of U.S. service members during a hostage crisis that took place amidst the Iranian Revolution of 1979. In January 1979, Iranian leader Mohammed Reza Shah Pahlavi fled into exile after a year of escalating protests. Iran's new leader, Ayatollah Khomeini, declared the country an Islamic republic, and his fundamentalist regime encouraged anti-American sentiment.

On November 4, 1979, a group of several hundred Iranian students seized the U.S. embassy in Tehran, taking 66 of its employees hostage. The captors released women and African American hostages during the next two weeks, but 53 Americans remained captive.

By the spring of 1980, diplomatic negotiations had reached a stalemate, and President Jimmy Carter authorized a secret military operation, to begin on April 24, to rescue the remaining hostages. During mission preparations, however, a helicopter collided with a transport plane, killing eight American service personnel. The rescue mission was aborted. Iran did not release the hostages until January 20, 1981 — day 444 of their captivity, and the day of President Ronald Reagan's inauguration.



Dedicated in 1983, the Iran Rescue Mission Memorial consists of a white granite column with a bronze plaque listing the names and ranks of those who lost their lives during the mission. Three of the men — Maj. Richard Bakke, Maj. Harold Lewis Jr. and Sgt. Joel Mayo — is buried in a grave marked by a common headstone, located about 25 feet from the group memorial.

KOREAN WAR MEMORIAL BENCH



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On July 27, 1987, the Korean War Veterans Association and the veterans' services organization No Greater Love dedicated the Korean War Memorial Contemplative Bench in a ceremony attended by Korean War veterans, South Korea's ambassador, the secretary of Veterans Affairs and the founder and president of No Greater Love. The bench is located on the north side of the Memorial Amphitheater, next to trees donated by South Korea (a Korean white pine tree, dedicated by President Roh Tae Woo in 1989, and a Korean mountain ash).

The bench's inscription reads:

"The Beginning of the End of War Lies in Remembrance" – Herman Wouk

In sacred memory of those Americans who gave their lives during the Korean War, 1950-1953

54,246 Died 8,177 Missing in Action 389 Unaccounted for POW'S

NURSES'S MEMORIAL



This area is known as the "Nurses Section." Against a background of evergreens, an 11-foot-tall white Tennessee marble statue appears to gaze reverently upon the deceased nurses who lie before her. Representing "The Spirit of Nursing," the figure wears simple attire with her hair pinned up, a practical style many early twentieth-century nurses adopted while working.

In September 1936, President Franklin D. Roosevelt received a request that "a suitable and respectable monument be erected to the Unknown Nurse in Arlington Cemetery." The Army's quartermaster general, responsible for all new memorials at the cemetery, denied the request, arguing that no unknown nurses were buried at Arlington. However, the superintendent of the Army Nurses Corp and the Navy Nurses Corp, Major Julia C. Stimson, continued advocating for a monument in memory of the Army and Navy nurses interred at Arlington National Cemetery. In May 1937, Roosevelt's secretary of war granted this request, and the quartermaster general approved the erection of "some suitable monument" on a rounded knoll south of Rear Admiral William T. Sampson's tomb.

Although the Commission of Fine Arts had suggested a male sculptor, Frances Rich was ultimately chosen to design the memorial.

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The daughter of silent film star Irene Rich, Frances Rich was a Smith College-educated artist and actress who studied sculpture with acclaimed teachers in the United States and Europe, appeared in six Hollywood films, and, during World War II, enlisted in the Navy WAVES (Women Accepted for Volunteer Emergency Service), in which she served as special assistant to the director. One of Rich's best-known works, the Nurses Memorial beautifully exemplifies art deco classicism. Characteristics of this style, popular during the 1930s, include gently curving forms and long, vertical lines of movement.

Unveiled in 1938, the statue initially honored nurses who died during their service in the Army or Navy. Its meaning has since expanded to include all nurses who served in the U.S. armed forces.

In July 1970, Navy Capt. Delores Cornelius, deputy director of the Navy Nurse Corps, received authorization to install a bronze plaque over the existing inscription on the Nurses Memorial. The plaque reads, "**This monument was erected in 1938 and rededicated in 1971 to commemorate devoted service to country and humanity by Army, Navy and Air Force Nurses.**"

PAN AMERICAN FLIGHT 103 CRASH IN LOCKERBIE, SCOTLAND



The Lockerbie Memorial memorializes the 270 lives lost in the terrorist bombing of Pan American Airlines Flight 103 on December 21, 1988, over Lockerbie, Scotland. Consisting of 270 blocks of red Scottish sandstone, the cairn was a gift from the people of Scotland to the people of the United States, financed entirely through private donations. A cairn is a traditional Scottish monument honoring the dead.

On December 21, 1988, Flight 103 was en route from Frankfurt, Germany to New York via London's Heathrow Airport. At 7:02 p.m., 27 minutes after leaving London, the plane exploded, raining fragments on the city of Lockerbie. Eleven of the 270 dead were on the ground. The 259 passengers and crew included citizens of 21 countries. Among them were 190 Americans, including 15 active duty military personnel and 10 veterans.

In 1993, Congress unanimously passed Senate Joint Resolution 129, designating Arlington National Cemetery as the site of the memorial cairn, and President Bill Clinton signed the bill into law on November 24, 1993.

On December 21, 1993, the fifth anniversary of the disaster, President Clinton delivered the keynote address at the groundbreaking ceremony.

The blocks of sandstone that comprise the cairn come from Corsehill Quarry near Annan, Scotland, about eight miles southeast of Lockerbie and below the flight path of Flight 103. Corsehill Quarry, operating since 1820, has provided stones for many buildings in the United States, most notably the base of the Statue of Liberty.

The following words are engraved on the cairn's base: "On 21 December 1988, a terrorist bomb destroyed Pan American Airlines Flight 103 over Lockerbie, Scotland, killing all on board and 11 on the ground. The 270 Scottish stones which compose this memorial cairn commemorate those who lost their lives in this attack against America."

A bronze plaque on the side of the cairn reads, "In remembrance of the two hundred seventy people killed in the terrorist bombing of Pan American Airways Flight 103 over Lockerbie, Scotland 21 December 1988. Presented by the Lockerbie Air Disaster Trust to the United States Of America."

9-11 PENTAGON GROUP BURIAL MARKER



On September 12, 2002, a funeral service was held in Memorial Amphitheater for the final remains of the 184 victims of the September 11, 2001 attack on the Pentagon. While the service honored all 184 victims, it offered special recognition to the five families who did not receive any recovered remains of their loved ones. Secretary of Defense Donald Rumsfeld offered words of condolence at the service, stating, "We remember your loss, our loss, our country's loss, and the loss of precious lives." Following the service, a group burial was held in Section 64. A five-sided granite group marker stands over the gravesite, bearing the names of all those who perished in the Pentagon or aboard American Airlines Flight 77.

SPACE SHUTTLE CHALLENGER

On January 28, 1986, Space Shuttle Challenger exploded just 73 seconds after takeoff, killing all seven crew members — including high school teacher Christa McAuliffe, who had been selected from among more than 11,000 applicants to become the first teacher in space.



It took nearly two months to recover the remains from the ocean floor, about 18 miles off the shore of Cape Canaveral, Florida. On May 20, 1986, the comingled cremated remains of the seven Challenger astronauts were buried at Arlington National Cemetery, in Section 46, Grave 1129. Two also have individual gravesites: Lt. Col. Francis R. "Dick" Scobee (Section 46, to the left of the memorial) and Commander Michael J. Smith (Section 7A, Grave 208).

Family members and NASA worked together to erect the memorial in Section 46, near Memorial Amphitheater. Approximately 400 people attended the dedication ceremony on the morning of March 21, 1987, including Vice President and Mrs. George Bush. The astronauts' faces and names are carved into the memorial marker: Commander Michael J. Smith; Commander Francis R. 'Dick' Scobee; Ronald E. McNair, mission specialist; Ellison Onizuka, mission specialist; S. Christa McAuliffe, payload specialist; Gregory B. Jarvis, payload specialist; Judith A. Resnik, mission specialist.

[The back of the marker features the famous aeronautical poem "High Flight,"](#) written by Royal Canadian Air Force pilot John Gillespie Magee, Jr. in 1941:

HIGH FLIGHT

Oh! I have slipped the surly bonds of earth and danced the skies on laughter-silvered wings;
Sunward I've climbed, and joined the tumbling mirth of sun-split clouds, — and done a hundred things.

You have not dreamed of — wheeled and soared and swung High in the sunlit silence. Hov'ring there,
I've chased the shouting wind along and flung My eager craft through footless halls of air.

Up, up the long, delirious, burning blue I've topped the windswept heights with easy grace.
The high un-trespassed sanctity of space

Where never lark nor even eagle flew — And, while with a silent lifting mind, I've trod
Put out my hand, and touched the face of God.

— John Gillespie Magee, Jr.

SPACE SHUTTLE COLUMBIA

On February 1, 2003, Space Shuttle Columbia was headed home after a 16-day scientific mission, its 28th venture into space.

As Columbia re-entered Earth's atmosphere, it suddenly burst into flames, killing all seven crew members: Richard "Rick" Husband, commander; William C. McCool, pilot; Michael P. Anderson, payload commander; David M. Brown, mission specialist; Kalpana Chawla, mission specialist; Laurel Blair Salton Clark, mission specialist; and Ilan Ramon, mission specialist.



In April 2003, Congress approved and President George W. Bush signed into law the Columbia Memorial Act, authorizing the secretary of the Army, in consultation with NASA, to place a memorial to the Columbia crew in Arlington National Cemetery. NASA administrator Sean O'Keefe, accompanied by more than 400 family members, former astronauts, and friends, dedicated the memorial on February 2, 2004.

Standing just a few feet away from the Space Shuttle Challenger Memorial, the marker features a silhouette of the space shuttle imprinted with the names of the astronauts and surrounded by seven stars.

In addition to the memorial, three Columbia astronauts whose remains could be identified individually have individual gravesites nearby:

Captain David Brown, U.S. Navy: Section 46, Grave 1180-3

Captain Laurel Blair Salton Clark, M.D., U.S. Navy: Section 46, Grave 1180-2

Lt. Col. Michael P. Anderson, U.S. Air Force: Section 46, Grave 1180-1

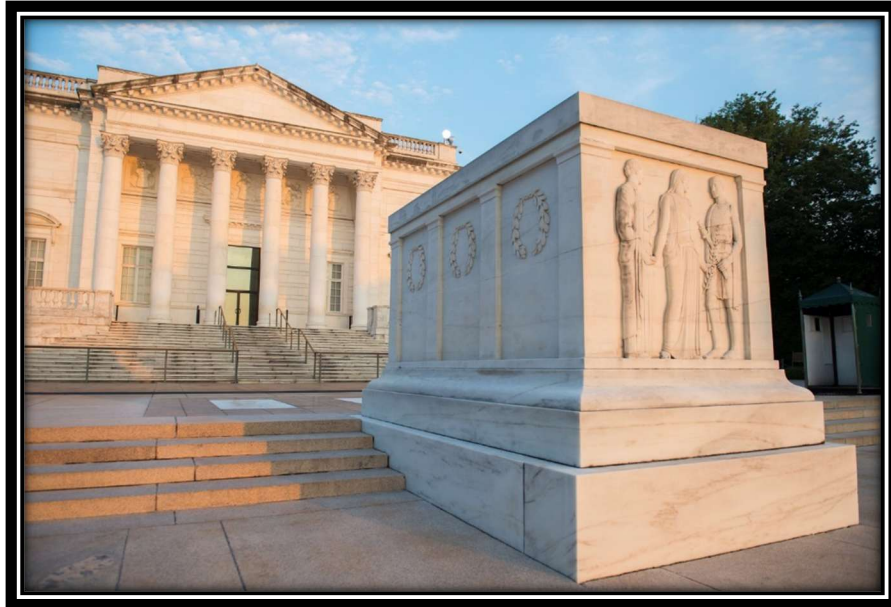
TOMB OF THE UNKNOWN SOLDIER

The Tomb of the Unknown Soldier is Arlington National Cemetery's most iconic memorial.

The neoclassical, white marble sarcophagus stands atop a hill overlooking Washington, D.C. Since 1921, it has provided a final resting place for one of America's unidentified World War I service members, and

Unknowns from later wars were added in 1958 and 1984. The Tomb has also served as a place of mourning and a site for reflection on military service.

Through the ages, one of the consequences of warfare has been large numbers of unidentified dead. Sometimes unidentified remains resulted from poor record keeping, the damage that weapons of war inflicted on bodies, or the haste required to bury the dead and mark gravesites. In the United States before the Civil War, unidentified remains were often buried in mass graves. At Arlington National Cemetery, these include unknown soldiers and sailors from the War of 1812 who were discovered buried at the Washington Barracks and reburied at Arlington National Cemetery in 1905.



BACKGROUND

During the Civil War (1861-1865), high casualty rates and lack of personal identification led to large numbers of unknowns originally buried along marching routes or battlefields. The system of national cemeteries was established in 1862 to ensure the proper burial of all service members. Still, many unknown remains were recovered in the years following the Civil War. At Arlington National Cemetery, there are individual Civil War unknown burials as well as the remains of 2,111 Union and Confederate soldiers buried beneath the [Tomb of the Civil War Unknowns](#). While exact numbers are unknown, estimates indicate that nearly half of the Civil War dead were never identified.

During the [Spanish-American War](#) (1898), the U.S. military's policy was to repatriate (return to the United States) the bodies of service members who died abroad. New Army regulations required that soldiers be buried in temporary graves with identifying information. The Army's Quartermaster Corps, which oversaw burials and repatriation of bodies, employed a burial corps. Identification rates went up significantly.

WORLD WAR ONE AND THE CREATION OF THE TOMB

During World War I, U.S. service members received aluminum identification discs, the precursors to "dog tags," to aid the process of identifying remains. The War Department created a new unit in the Quartermaster Corps, the Graves Registration Service, to oversee burials. During and after World War I, however, Americans debated whether bodies should be repatriated. With more than 100,000 U.S. casualties (compared to fewer than 3,000 in the Spanish-American War), repatriation was more challenging.

France and Great Britain, which suffered significantly higher casualties and more unknown deaths than the United States, barred repatriation of their citizens' remains. To ease the grief of their citizens, France and Great Britain each repatriated and buried one unknown soldier on Armistice Day, November 11, 1920. Great Britain buried its Unknown Warrior inside Westminster Abbey in London, and France buried its Unknown Soldier at the base of the Arc de Triomphe in Paris. These unknowns would stand in for other British and French service members whose remains could not be identified.

The American policy, by contrast, gave options to families of the war dead.

If requested by the next of kin, the remains of service members who died in Europe would be transported to anywhere in the United States at no cost to the family. Or, families could choose to bury their dead at permanent U.S. military cemeteries to be established in Europe.

In December 1920, New York Congressman and World War I veteran Hamilton Fish Jr. proposed legislation that provided for the interment of one unknown American soldier at a special tomb to be built in Arlington National Cemetery. The purpose of the legislation was "to bring home the body of an unknown American warrior who in himself represents no section, creed, or race in the late war and who typifies, moreover, the soul of America and the supreme sacrifice of her heroic dead."

In October 1921, four bodies of unidentified U.S. military personnel were exhumed from different American military cemeteries in France. On October 23, 1921, the four caskets arrived at the city hall of Châlons-sur-Marne (now called Châlons-en-Champagne), France.

Town officials and members of the U.S. Army's Quartermaster Corps had prepared the city hall for the selection ceremony. Early on the morning of October 24, 1921, Maj. Robert P. Harbold of the Quartermaster Corps, aided by French and American soldiers, rearranged the caskets so that each rested on a shipping case other than the one in which it had arrived. Major Harbold then chose Sgt. Edward F. Younger of Headquarters Company, 2nd Battalion, 50th Infantry, American Forces in Germany, to select the Unknown Soldier. Sgt. Younger selected the Unknown by placing a spray of white roses on one of the caskets.

From Châlons-sur-Marne, the Unknown journeyed by caisson and rail to the port town of Le Havre, France. From Le Havre, the USS Olympia transported the Unknown Soldier's casket to Washington, D.C. The Unknown arrived at the Washington Navy Yard on November 9, 1921. After arriving in Washington, D.C. on November 9, 1921, the Unknown lay in state in the U.S. Capitol Rotunda. About 90,000 visitors paid their respects during the public visiting period on November 10, 1921.

On November 11, 1921, the Unknown was placed on a horse-drawn caisson and carried in a procession through Washington, D.C., and across the Potomac River. A state funeral ceremony was held at Arlington National Cemetery's new [Memorial Amphitheater](#), and the Unknown was interred in the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier. Nationwide, Americans observed two minutes of silence at the beginning of the ceremony. President Warren G. Harding officiated at the ceremony and placed the Medal of Honor, the nation's highest military decoration, on the casket. Numerous foreign dignitaries presented their nations' highest awards, as well.

Originally, the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier consisted of a simple marble slab. During its early years, thousands of visitors came to Arlington National Cemetery to mourn at the Tomb and to pay their respects to the Unknown Soldier and the military personnel he represented.

The Tomb sarcophagus is decorated with three wreaths on each side panel (north and south). On the front (east), three figures represent Peace, Victory, and Valor. The back (west) features the inscription: "Here rests in honored glory an American soldier known but to God."

WORLD WAR 2 AND KOREAN UNKNOWNNS

Following World War II, some Americans supported the idea of interring and honoring an Unknown from that war. However, the start of the Korean War in 1950 delayed those plans. In August 1956, President Dwight D. Eisenhower approved the selection and interment of Unknowns from both World War II and Korea.

Fought on four continents, World War II complicated the selection of an Unknown. The chosen Unknown needed to represent all unidentified American dead, not just those from one theater of the war. In 1958, the Army exhumed 13 bodies from military cemeteries across North Africa and Europe and brought them to the Epinal American Cemetery and Memorial in France.

On May 12, 1958, Major General Edward J. O'Neill placed a red and white wreath on one of the 13 caskets, selecting the Unknown who would represent the Trans-Atlantic (Europe and North Africa) Theater of World War II. The selected casket was then taken aboard the USS Blandy for its journey to the United States.

To represent the Pacific Theater of World War II, the Army exhumed five bodies from Fort McKinley American Cemetery in the Philippines (now called Manila American Cemetery) and the National Memorial Cemetery of the Pacific ("The Punch Bowl") in Hawaii. At the same time, they exhumed four bodies from the Korean War that were also buried at the National Memorial Cemetery of the Pacific. All nine caskets were brought to Hickam Air Force Base, Hawaii. On May 15, 1958, Army Master Sergeant Ned Lyle selected the Korean War Unknown. The next day, Air Force Colonel Glenn T. Eagleston selected the World War II Trans-Pacific Unknown. Both caskets were flown to Guantanamo Bay, Cuba, before being loaded aboard the USS Boston.

The USS Blandy and USS Boston met the USS Canberra off the coast of Virginia. On May 26, 1958, all three caskets were placed on the deck of the Canberra, with the Korean War Unknown placed between the two World War II Unknowns. Navy Hospital Corpsman 1st Class William R. Charette, a Medal of Honor recipient from the Korean War, then selected the World War II Unknown. The caskets of the World War II and Korean War Unknowns were then transported to Washington, D.C. aboard the USS Blandy, while the remaining World War II Unknown received a solemn burial at sea.

Both Unknowns arrived in Washington, D.C. on May 28, 1958, and lay in state in the U.S. Capitol Rotunda for two days. Two days later, the Unknowns were transported to Arlington National Cemetery and interred in crypts to the west of the World War I Unknown.

VIETNAM WAR UNKNOWN

Before the Vietnam War ended, Arlington National Cemetery began making preparations to add a third crypt to the Tomb. However, many people believed that advances in technology would mean that all remains from Vietnam could eventually be identified.

In response to mounting political pressure to recognize a Vietnam War unknown, President Jimmy Carter and Max Cleland, Administrator of the United States Veteran Administration and a Vietnam veteran, dedicated a bronze plaque honoring American service members in the Vietnam War on Veterans Day, November 11, 1978, at Memorial Amphitheater.

By May 1984, only one set of recovered American remains from Vietnam had not been fully identified. In a ceremony held at Pearl Harbor, Hawaii on May 17, 1984, Medal of Honor recipient Marine Corps Sergeant Major Allan Jay Kellogg, Jr. designated the remains as the Vietnam War Unknown. The casket was then transported to Travis Air Force Base, California aboard the USS Brewton.

In California, the Vietnam War Unknown was loaded on a C-141B Starlifter and flown to Andrews Air Force Base, Maryland. The Vietnam War Unknown lay in state in the U.S. Capitol Rotunda from May 25 to 28, 1984. On Memorial Day, May 28, a military procession transported the casket to Arlington National Cemetery for burial. On Memorial Day 1984, President Ronald Reagan presided over the interment ceremony at Arlington. In his eulogy, Reagan assured the audience that the government would continue looking for the Vietnam War's missing-in-action (MIA) personnel. Meanwhile, the Vietnam War Unknown would lay at rest at the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier for almost 14 years.

The Department of Defense and civilian partners continued working to identify remains recovered from Vietnam. Through these efforts, they reviewed evidence that suggested the Vietnam War Unknown was likely Air Force 1st Lt. Michael Joseph Blassie, a pilot who had been shot down in 1972. At the request of Blassie's family, the Department of Defense exhumed the remains from the Vietnam Unknown's crypt on May 14, 1998. Using DNA testing, scientists positively identified the remains as those of Blassie.

Following the wishes of his family, Blassie was reinterred at Jefferson Barracks National Cemetery in St. Louis, Missouri. The crypt designated for the Vietnam War Unknown remains vacant. On September 17, 1999 — National POW/MIA Recognition Day — it was rededicated to honor all missing U.S. service members from the Vietnam War.

GUARDING THE TOMB

In March 1926, soldiers from nearby Fort Myer were first assigned to guard the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier. The guards, present only during daylight hours, discouraged visitors from climbing or stepping on the Tomb. In 1937, the guards became a 24/7 presence, standing watch over the Unknown Soldier at all times.

The 3rd U.S. Infantry Regiment, known as "The Old Guard," was designated as the Army's official ceremonial unit on April 6, 1948. At that time, The Old Guard began guarding the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier. Soldiers of The Old Guard also serve as escorts to the president and conduct military ceremonies in and around Washington, D.C., including military funeral escorts at Arlington National Cemetery.

Soldiers who volunteer to become Tomb Guards must undergo a strict selection process and intensive training. [Each element of the Tomb Guard's routine has meaning.](#) The Guard marches 21 steps down the black mat behind the Tomb, turns and faces east for 21 seconds, turns and faces north for 21 seconds, and then takes 21 steps down the mat. Next, the Guard executes a sharp "shoulder-arms" movement to place his/her weapon on the shoulder closest to the visitors, signifying that he or she stands between the Tomb and any possible threat. The number 21 symbolizes the highest symbolic military honor that can be bestowed: the 21-gun salute.

WREATH LAYINGS AND VISITORS TODAY

Laying a wreath at the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier has long been a way for individuals and organizations to honor the sacrifices of American service members. Presidents, politicians, public figures, and foreign dignitaries have all paid their respects in this way. Honor Flights, which honor our nation's veterans with all-expense paid trips to see the memorials in Washington, D.C., almost always visit the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier and sometimes lay wreaths. [The opportunity to participate in a wreath-laying ceremony is also open to the general public, including school groups.](#) In addition, each year, millions of people from around the world visit the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier. Some visit to honor military service and sacrifice; some to mourn a loved one; and some because of the Tomb's historical and national significance.

One hundred years after the World War I Unknown's burial, the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier continues to be a powerful symbol of service and sacrifice, mourning and memory.

SS THRESHER NATIONAL COMMEMORATIVE MONUMENT

Dedicated on September 26, 2019, this monument commemorates the service and sacrifice of the crew of the USS Thresher (SSN-593), the world's most technologically advanced nuclear-powered submarine of its day. On April 10, 1963, Thresher sank during deep-diving tests off the coast of Massachusetts, killing all 129 personnel aboard 16 officers, 96 enlisted sailors, and 17 civilian technicians. It was the deadliest accident in submarine history, leading the Navy to establish the SUBSAFE Submarine Safety Program.

The USS Thresher (named after the thresher shark) was built at the Portsmouth Naval Shipyard in Kittery, Maine, and commissioned in August 1961. It was the lead ship of a class of nuclear-powered attack submarines, "silent guardians" created to find and destroy Soviet submarines. It had a top speed of over 20 knots and a maximum operational depth greater than 400 feet, and it displaced 4,300 tons of water when submerged.



On the morning of April 10, 1963, Thresher departed from Portsmouth to perform deep-diving tests, accompanied by the submarine rescue ship USS Skylark. Fifteen minutes after reaching its test depth, it communicated via underwater telephone that it was experiencing difficulties. Amid garbled transmissions, the Skylark crew reported hearing a sudden noise — “like air rushing into an air tank” — and then, silence. Repeated efforts to reestablish contact failed, and a rescue ship began to recover debris. After a fifteen-ship search operation, on April 11 the Navy declared the Thresher lost at sea. A Naval Court of Inquiry later determined that the accident was likely caused by the failure of a salt-water piping system joint, which in turn led to flooding in the engine room.

The loss of Thresher was the genesis of the SUBSAFE Submarine Safety Program, established in June 1963. Affirming the Navy's commitment to a culture of safety, the program requires annual training of personnel, non-negotiable certification requirements, and internal and external audits. The program has been successful: no SUBSAFE-certified submarine has ever been lost. As its inscription states, the commemorative monument honors “the 129 men lost aboard USS Thresher (SSN-593) and their SUBSAFE legacy.”

CONFEDERATE MEMORIAL

The history of the Confederate Memorial embodies the complex and contested legacy of the Civil War at Arlington National Cemetery, and in American culture generally.

In 1900, Congress authorized Confederate remains to be reinterred at Arlington National Cemetery, which designated a special section for them (in what is now Section 16). The Confederate Memorial was erected there in 1914. By the early 1900s, it had become a tradition to establish a new section at Arlington for the dead from a particular war, followed by a commemorative monument. In Section 22, where many soldiers and sailors from the Spanish-American War are buried, the Spanish-American War Monument and the Rough Riders Monument memorialize that conflict. After World War I service members were repatriated and buried in Sections 18 and 19, and the Argonne Cross was dedicated in Section 18. In this sense, the creation of a Confederate section and memorial followed customary practice at Arlington.

However, to understand more fully why Confederate graves are at a former Union cemetery, and to interpret the memorial's symbolism, it is necessary to delve more deeply into the historical context.

By the turn of the twentieth century, [*Arlington had become a truly national cemetery*](#), a transformation that occurred amidst reconciliation between North and South, enduring racial inequality, and a new war. Reconstruction — the U.S. government's efforts to reunify the nation and transform the South's former slavery-based society — effectively ended in 1877.



That year, President Rutherford B. Hayes agreed to withdraw federal troops from Southern states, allowing for sectional reconciliation but also the systemic disenfranchisement of African Americans, enforced by white violence and racial segregation in the South. In 1898, mobilization for war against Spain, and the United States' expanding global power, reinforced a sense of national unity — at least among many white Americans.

In this context, the U.S. government reassessed its policies on Confederate burials. Although the Tomb of the Civil War Unknowns likely contained the remains of both Union and Confederate dead, Arlington had been a U.S. Army cemetery, and for years after the Civil War, Confederate veterans could not be buried there. However, on December 14, 1898 — four days after the Spanish-American War ended — President William McKinley kicked off his “Peace Jubilee” nationwide tour with a speech in Atlanta in which he proclaimed, “In the spirit of fraternity we should share with you in the care of the graves of Confederate soldiers.... Sectional feeling no longer holds back the love we feel for each other. The old flag again waves over us in peace with new glories.”

Notably, this “spirit of fraternity” did not include African Americans. In 1871, a group of black soldiers had petitioned the War Department to relocate the graves of hundreds of United States Colored Troops (USCT) from the “Lower Cemetery,” where they were buried alongside former slaves and poor whites, to the main cemetery near [Arlington House](#), where white Civil War veterans lay at rest. The War Department denied the petition. Arlington National Cemetery would remain segregated until 1948 when President Harry S. Truman desegregated the armed forces by executive order.

Meanwhile, the United Confederate Veterans (UCV) identified Confederate graves around the Washington, D.C. area and successfully petitioned the government to have those remains transferred to Arlington. On June 6, 1900, Congress appropriated \$2,500 for the removal and reinterment of Confederate remains. By 1902, 262 Confederate bodies were interred in a specially designated section, Section 16.

Unlike the orderly rows in the rest of the cemetery, graves in the Confederate section were arranged in concentric rings. Their headstones also looked different: while having the same dimensions as regular government headstones, the Confederate headstones featured pointed tops. The cemetery added more Confederate graves over the years, eventually totaling more than 400.

On June 7, 1903, the first Confederate Memorial Day ceremonies were held in Arlington's Confederate section. President Theodore Roosevelt sent a floral arrangement, beginning a tradition continued by nearly every U.S. president. In 2009, President Barack Obama modified the tradition, sending two wreaths: one to the Confederate Memorial, the other to Washington, D.C.'s African American Civil War Memorial, in honor of U.S. Colored Troops.

In 1906, with Secretary of War William Howard Taft's approval, the United Daughters of the Confederacy (a hereditary organization of Southern women) began raising funds to erect a memorial in the Confederate section. Through such voluntary civic organizations, women-led many late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century efforts to commemorate wars and to mourn the dead — and, in so doing, women gained influence in public life even before they won the right to vote. (In another example of women's commemorative efforts, the National Society of the Colonial Dames of America was responsible for creating the Spanish-American War Memorial.)

Unveiled in 1914, the Confederate Memorial was designed by noted American sculptor Moses Jacob Ezekiel, a Confederate veteran and the first Jewish graduate of Virginia Military Institute. The elaborately designed monument offers a nostalgic, mythologized vision of the Confederacy, including highly sanitized depictions of slavery. Standing on a 32-foot-tall pedestal, a bronze, classical female figure, crowned with olive leaves, represents the American South. She holds a laurel wreath, a plow stock, and a pruning hook, with a Biblical inscription at her feet: “They have beat their swords into plough-shares and their spears into pruning hooks.” The statue stands on a pedestal with four cinerary urns, one for each year of the war, and is supported by a frieze with 14 shields, one for each of the 11 Confederate states and the border states of Maryland, Kentucky, and Missouri. Thirty-two life-sized figures depict mythical gods alongside Southern soldiers and civilians.

Two of these figures are portrayed as African American: an enslaved woman depicted as a “Mammy,” holding the infant child of a white officer, and an enslaved man following his owner to war. An inscription of the Latin phrase “*Victrix causa diis placuit sed victa Caton*” (“The victorious cause was pleasing to the gods, but the lost cause to Cato”) construes the South’s secession as a noble “Lost Cause.” This narrative of the Lost Cause, which romanticized the pre-Civil War South and denied the horrors of slavery, fueled a white backlash against Reconstruction and the rights that the 13th, 14th, and 15th Amendments (1865-1870) had granted to African Americans. The image of the faithful slave, embodied in the two figures on the memorial, appeared widely in American popular culture during the 1910s through 1930s, perhaps most famously in the 1939 film “Gone with the Wind.”

Sculptor Moses Ezekiel was buried at the base of his creation in 1921, after being honored at the first funeral ceremony in the newly built Memorial Amphitheater. Three other Confederate soldiers lie next to him: Lt. Harry C. Marmaduke of the Confederate Navy, Capt. John M. Hickey of the Second Missouri Infantry and Brig. Gen. Marcus J. Wright commanded brigades at the battles of Shiloh and Chickamauga.

The Confederate Memorial offers an opportunity for visitors to reflect on the history and meanings of the Civil War, slavery, and the relationship between military service, citizenship, and race in America. This memorial, along with the segregated United States Colored Troops graves in [Section 27](#), invites us to understand how politics and culture have historically shaped how Americans have buried and commemorated the dead. Memorialization at a national cemetery became an important marker of citizenship — which, in the post-Reconstruction era, was granted to white Civil War veterans, Confederate or Union, but not to African American soldiers who had served their country.

In such ways, the history of Arlington National Cemetery allows us to better understand the complex history of the United States.

PLEASE NOTE

As of Dec. 22, 2023, the bronze elements of the Confederate Memorial **were removed from Arlington National Cemetery** and are currently stored in a secure Department of Defense facility in Virginia. Army National Military Cemeteries undertook this action to comply with a Congressionally-mandated requirement to remove the Confederate Memorial by Jan 1, 2024.

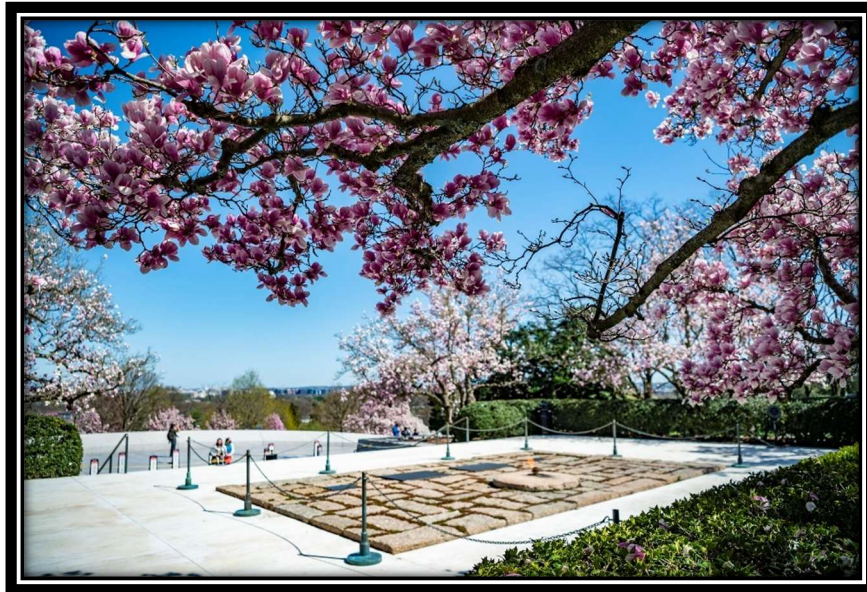
After a congressionally established naming commission determined that a Confederate Memorial must be removed from Arlington National Cemetery **because it depicts the Confederacy and slavery**,

NRS successfully defended multiple lawsuits challenging the Department of Defense's removal of the Memorial. Apr 17, 2024.

For background and information on the process, please copy and paste the below link into your browser

<https://www.arlingtoncemetery.mil/About/Confederate-Memorial-Removal>

PRESIDENT JOHN F. KENNEDY GRAVESITE



John F. Kennedy made his first formal visit to Arlington National Cemetery on Veterans Day, November 11, 1961, to place a wreath at the [Tomb of the Unknown Soldier](#). After the ceremony, President Kennedy spoke to more than 5,000 people gathered in the [Memorial Amphitheater](#).

Eleven days before Kennedy's assassination, he returned to Arlington for the 1963 Veterans Day services. This time, he did not address the crowd in the amphitheater. On November 22, 1963, while on a campaign trip to Dallas, President Kennedy was shot and killed.

Kennedy is one of only two presidents buried at Arlington. The other is William Howard Taft, who died in 1930. At the time of Kennedy's death, many believed that he would be buried in Brookline, Massachusetts, where he was born and raised.

However, First Lady Jacqueline Kennedy wanted her husband's gravesite to be widely accessible to the American public.

In selecting a location, she consulted with the president's brother, Robert F. Kennedy, and Secretary of Defense Robert S. McNamara—both of whom are now also buried at Arlington. The original gravesite was located on a sloping hillside along an axis line between Arlington House and the Lincoln Memorial.

At 3 p.m. on November 25, 1963, the state funeral of President Kennedy began. Mourners included President Charles de Gaulle of France, Chancellor Ludwig Erhard of the Federal Republic of Germany, Emperor Haile Selassie of Ethiopia, and Prince Philip of the United Kingdom. Fifty Navy and Air Force jets flew overhead, followed by Air Force One, which dipped its wing in a final tribute.

Millions of people watched live coverage of the funeral on television, leading to an unprecedented increase in demand for burials at Arlington National Cemetery.

The initial plot was 20 feet by 30 feet and was surrounded by a white picket fence. During the first year after Kennedy's death, up to 3,000 people per hour visited his gravesite, and on weekends an estimated

50,000 people visited. Three years after Kennedy's death, more than 16 million people had visited the gravesite.

Because of the large crowds, cemetery officials and members of the Kennedy family decided that a more suitable site should be constructed. Construction began in 1965 and was completed on July 20, 1967. An eternal flame, lit by Mrs. Kennedy, burns from the center of a five-foot circular granite stone at the head of the grave.

The Kennedy family paid actual costs in the immediate grave area, while the federal government funded improvements in the surrounding area that accommodated the visiting public. The 1965 Public Works appropriation included \$1,770,000 for this purpose.

Other Kennedy family members are buried nearby, including two of President Kennedy's brothers: [Robert F. Kennedy](#), who was assassinated on June 6, 1968, was interred at Arlington in 1971; [Senator Edward M. Kennedy](#) was buried in an adjacent plot after his death in August 2009. There is a memorial marker for JFK's eldest brother, [Joseph P. Kennedy Jr.](#) [Former first lady Jacqueline Bouvier Kennedy Onassis was laid to rest next to President Kennedy on May 23, 1994.](#)

[ROBERT F. KENNEDY GRAVESITE](#)



Robert F. Kennedy — President John F. Kennedy's younger brother, and a World War II U.S. Navy veteran who served as attorney general, senator, and 1968 Democratic presidential candidate — was shot in Los Angeles on June 5, 1968, shortly after winning the California Democratic primary. He died the next morning.

After a funeral mass at St. Patrick's Cathedral in New York City on June 8, 1968, a train transported RFK's remains to Washington, D.C., to be buried next to the gravesite of his brother at Arlington National Cemetery. As the train stopped in cities along the route, thousands of Americans gathered to pay tribute to the slain leader. The long transport delayed the train's arrival at Union Station until 9:10 p.m., and cemetery officials quickly changed the funeral plans to accommodate an evening interment. Floodlights were placed around the open grave, and service members distributed 1,500 candles to the mourners.

Thirteen pallbearers carried the casket from the train, including astronaut [John Glenn](#), former Secretary of Defense [Robert S. McNamara](#), [General Maxwell Taylor](#), Robert's eldest son Joe Kennedy, and his brother [Senator Edward Kennedy](#).

A ceremonial motorcade stopped first at the Lincoln Memorial, where the U.S. Marine Corps Band played "The Battle Hymn of the Republic," and arrived at Arlington at 10:30 p.m. The brief graveside service was conducted by Terence Cardinal Cooke, Archbishop of New York. Afterward, John Glenn presented a folded flag to Ethel and Joe Kennedy on behalf of the United States.

In 1971, a more elaborate gravesite was completed at the request of the Kennedy family. Architect I.M. Pei (who also designed the East Building of the National Gallery of Art) designed the new gravesite, which retained the simple, white Christian cross of the original and added a granite plaza, like that of JFK's adjoining gravesite. Its two inscriptions quote two of Senator Kennedy's most notable addresses.

– "It is from numberless diverse acts of courage and belief that human history is shaped. Each time a man stands up for an ideal act to improve the lot of others or strikes out against injustice, he sends forth a tiny ripple of hope, and crossing each other from a million different centers of energy and daring those ripples build a current that can sweep down the mightiest wall of oppression and resistance." – Robert F. Kennedy, South Africa, June 6, 1966.

– "Some men see things as they are and ask 'Why?' I dream things that never were and ask, 'Why not?'" – Robert F. Kennedy, quoting playwright George Bernard Shaw in his 1968 presidential campaign.

[ARLINGTON HOUSE, THE ROBERT E. LEE MEMORIAL](#)

Arlington House, constructed between 1802 and 1818, was the nation's first memorial to George Washington. In 1778, John Parke Custis—the son of Martha Washington and her first husband, Daniel Parke Custis—purchased 1,100 acres of land in northern Virginia, on rolling hills overlooking Washington, D.C. In 1802, John Parke Custis's son, George Washington Parke Custis (the first president's adopted grandson), inherited the property, then known as Mount Washington.

Custis decided to construct a Greek Revival-style mansion there as his home and a place to display his large collection of George Washington heirlooms and memorabilia such as furniture, silver, china, and family portraits. The estate was a working plantation, and the mansion, called Arlington House, was built by enslaved African Americans. George Washington Parke Custis and his wife, Mary Lee Fitzhugh, lived at Arlington House until they died in 1857 and 1853, respectively. They are buried in what is now Section 13 of Arlington National Cemetery.

The Custis's only child, Mary Anna Randolph Custis, married her childhood friend and distant cousin, Robert E. Lee, in June 1831. A West Point graduate and the son of a three-term Virginia governor, Robert E. Lee commanded the Confederate Army during the Civil War. The Lees inherited the Custis estate in 1857 — including 196 enslaved persons, who lived and worked on the plantation.



Arlington House, with the gravesite of President John F. Kennedy in the foreground, March 2020.

After Virginia seceded from the United States on May 24, 1861, the Lees left Arlington House, never to return. The U.S. Army then occupied their estate, located on strategic high ground across from the nation's capital, as a camp and headquarters. U.S. troops constructed forts on the property, including Fort Whipple (now Fort Myer) and Fort McPherson (now Section 11). Because Mrs. Lee failed to pay taxes in person, as when required by law, the federal government confiscated the estate, purchasing it on January 11, 1864 "for Government use, for war, military, charitable, and educational purposes."



Meanwhile, the war's mounting human toll had overwhelmed the capacity of cemeteries in the D.C. area. Brigadier General Montgomery C. Meigs, quartermaster general of the U.S. Army, authorized military burials on the Arlington property — the presence of graves, he believed, would deter the Lees from ever returning. On May 13, 1864, Private William Christman became, and on June 15, 1864, the Army formally designated 200 acres of the property as a military cemetery. Meigs himself was later buried within 100 yards of Arlington House, along with his wife, father, and son.

Throughout the war, the Arlington estate also supported thousands of African Americans fleeing enslavement in the South. On December 4, 1863, the federal government dedicated [Freedman's Village](#), a planned community for freed slaves on the southern portion of the property. Freedman's Village grew to a community of 1,500, with a hospital, two churches, schools, and a home for the elderly.

Freed African Americans lived and farmed there until 1900 when the government closed Freedman's Village and incorporated the land into Arlington National Cemetery.

Neither Robert E. Lee nor his wife, as title holder, ever attempted to recover control of Arlington House. In 1874, Lee's eldest son, George Washington Custis Lee, sued the U.S. government for the return of the Arlington property, claiming that it had been illegally confiscated. In December 1882, the Supreme Court ruled in Lee's favor. A few months later, in March 1883, the federal government purchased the property from Lee for \$150,000 (over \$4 million today), and Arlington National Cemetery continued its mission as a burial ground for U.S. service members and their families.

BEIRUT BARRACKS MEMORIAL



The Beirut Barracks Memorial honors the 241 American service members who lost their lives in the October 23, 1983 bombing of a U.S. Marines Corps barracks in Beirut, Lebanon, during the Lebanese Civil War. Two truck bombs, detonated by suicide bombers, struck buildings that housed U.S. and French military members of a multinational peacekeeping force, killing a total of 299 service personnel (241 American, 58 French), along with six civilians and the two suicide bombers. It was the deadliest single-day attack against U.S. Marines since the battle over Iwo Jima in 1945.

Dedicated in 1984 on the first anniversary of the attack, the memorial is located beneath a cedar tree in Section 59 of the cemetery. Its inscription reads, "Let peace take root. This cedar of Lebanon tree grows in living memory of the Americans killed in the Beirut terrorist attack and all victims of terrorism throughout the world."

Twenty-one U.S. service members killed in the bombing are buried near the marker.

CHAPLIN'S HILL MONUMENTS

Military chaplains from four wars rest on Chaplains Hill in Section 2 of Arlington National Cemetery.



Those buried here include the Army's first chief of chaplains, Col. John T. Axton, a veteran of World War I; World War II's chief of chaplains, Maj. Gen. William R. Arnold, who was the first chaplain to become a general; and Maj. Charles Joseph Watters served in Vietnam and posthumously received the Medal of Honor for his selfless actions on November 19, 1967. Unarmed, Watters was aiding fallen comrades when he was killed by a bomb explosion.

On May 5, 1926, chaplains who served in World War I dedicated the Chaplains Monument to 23 chaplains who died in that war.

Two quotations are inscribed on the cenotaph: "Greater love hath no man than this, that a man lay down his life for his friends" (the Bible, John 15:13) and "To you from failing hands we throw the torch — be yours to hold it high" (from John McCrae's famous commemorative poem, "In Flanders Fields").

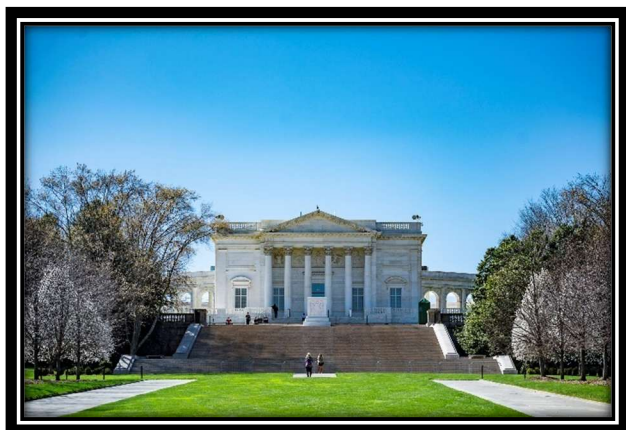
A second monument, to 134 Protestant chaplains who lost their lives in the two world wars, was dedicated on October 26, 1981. It bears the inscription, "To the glory of God and the memory of the chaplains who died in the service of their country, World War I and II."

A monument to 83 Catholic chaplains who died in World War II, the Korean War, and the Vietnam War was dedicated on May 21, 1989. Father (Maj.) William Barragy, the first American chaplain to die in Vietnam, is among those named on the monument. Barragy was killed on May 4, 1966, in a helicopter crash with 20 men on a mission for the Army's 101st Airborne Division, and posthumously received the Legion of Merit. The monument's inscription reads, "May God grant peace to them and to the nation they served so well."

Most recently, a monument to 14 Jewish chaplains who died on active duty in the U.S. armed forces was dedicated on October 24, 2011. Its inscriptions include a Biblical quotation: "They were swifter than eagles, they were stronger than lions" (Samuel II, 1:22).

THE MEMORIAL AMPHITHEATER

Arlington National Cemetery's Memorial Amphitheater was dedicated on May 15, 1920. While Memorial Day ceremonies are held throughout the United States, many consider the services at Memorial Amphitheater to be the nation's official ceremony honoring American service members. The president of the United States traditionally gives an address during Memorial Day ceremonies at the amphitheater.



Some 5,000 visitors attend each of the three major annual memorial services in the Amphitheater, which take place on Easter, Memorial Day, and Veterans Day and are sponsored by the U.S. Army Military District of Washington. The Easter sunrise service begins at 6 a.m.; Memorial Day and Veterans Day services begin at 11 a.m. Many military organizations also conduct annual memorial services at the amphitheater.

By the early 1900s, Arlington National Cemetery's original amphitheater — now called the James R. Tanner Amphitheater — could no longer accommodate the crowds that flocked to ceremonies held there. Efforts to construct a new amphitheater were led by Judge Ivory G. Kimball, an active member of the Grand Army of the Republic (a fraternal organization for Union veterans of the Civil War). For years, Kimball and the GAR lobbied Congress to authorize the construction of a place for the public to honor American service members.

Finally, in 1913, Congress passed legislation authorizing the construction of Memorial Amphitheater. President William Howard Taft (one of only two presidents buried at Arlington) signed that legislation into law on March 4, 1913. Judge Kimball participated in the groundbreaking ceremony on March 1, 1915, but did not live to see his dream completed. Ivory Kimball died on May 15, 1916, and was buried in Section 3 of the cemetery, near the Memorial Amphitheater he campaigned to build.

President Woodrow Wilson placed the cornerstone of the Memorial Amphitheater on October 13, 1915. By Armistice Day on November 11, 1918, nearly all of the building's exterior was complete. Interior construction was completed in June 1919. Designed by Thomas Hastings, the colonnaded building consists primarily of Vermont-quarried Danby marble. Its interior spaces include the Memorial Chapel and Memorial Display Room, the latter of which features exhibits on the history of Arlington National Cemetery and the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier.

A copper box placed in the cornerstone contains copies of the Bible, the Declaration of Independence, and the Constitution; a U.S. flag; designs and plans for the amphitheater; a map of Pierre Charles

L'Enfant's design for Washington, D.C.; one of each U.S. coin and postage stamp in use in 1915; an autographed photo of President Woodrow Wilson; and other documents about the history of the amphitheater and the nation's capital.

Inscriptions on the frieze above the colonnade list 44 battles fought by the U.S. military, from the American Revolution through the Spanish-American War. The names of 14 U.S. Army generals and 14 U.S. Navy admirals (all from before World War I) are inscribed on either side of the stage.

MEDAL OF HONOR RECIPIENTS

THERE IS NO SINGLE MONUMENT OR MEMORIAL

More than 400 Medal of Honor recipients are represented at Arlington National Cemetery, ranging from the Civil War to current conflicts.



There are three different types of Medal of Honor today: the original star shape established in 1861, which the Navy, Marine Corps, and Coast Guard have retained; a wreath version designed in 1904 for the Army; and an altered wreath version for the Air Force, adopted in 1965. All three types are worn suspended below a neck ribbon.

On December 9, 1861, Iowa Senator James W. Grimes introduced a bill designed to "promote the efficiency of the Navy" by authorizing the production and distribution of "medals of honor." On December 21, 1861, the bill passed, authorizing 200 such medals to be produced "which shall be bestowed upon such petty officers, seamen, landsmen, and marines as shall distinguish themselves by their gallantry in action and other seaman-like qualities during the present war" [the Civil War]. President Abraham Lincoln signed the bill, inaugurating the Navy Medal of Honor.

Two months later, on February 17, 1862, Massachusetts Senator Henry Wilson introduced a similar bill to authorize the president "to distribute medals to privates in the Army of the United States who shall distinguish themselves in battle." The bill passed both houses of Congress, President Lincoln signed it, and on July 12, 1862, the Army Medal of Honor was established.

On August 10, 1956, legislation authorized the United States Air Force (established as a separate service branch in 1947) to create its own Medal of Honor. In 1965, the Air Force introduced its distinctive medal, which is similar to the Army's wreath design but larger and featuring the head of the Statue of Liberty.

Arlington National Cemetery is the final resting place for Medal of Honor recipients from the following conflicts:

Indian Wars
Civil War
Spanish American War
Philippine Insurrection
Boxer Rebellion
Mexican Service Campaign (Vera Cruz)
Haitian Campaign
World War I
Second Nicaraguan Campaign
World War II
Korean War
Vietnam War
Operation Iraqi Freedom
Operation Enduring Freedom (Afghanistan)

THE McCLELLAN GATE



McClellan Gate marks the original entrance to Arlington National Cemetery. Named for Civil War General George B. McClellan, the reddish-brown archway remains one of the cemetery's most iconic landmarks, towering 30 feet above the ground. Atop the arch facing east, the name "McClellan" is inscribed in gold, above lines from Theodore O'Hara's poem "Bivouac of the Dead" (1847): "On fame's eternal camping ground their silent tents are spread / And glory guards with solemn round, the bivouac of the dead." Other lines from the poem are on the west-facing arch: "Rest on embalmed and sainted dead, dear as the blood ye gave / No impious footsteps here shall tread on the herbage of your grave." Like McClellan, O'Hara fought in the Mexican-American War (1846-1848) and wrote the poem to honor fallen soldiers from that

conflict. However, "Bivouac of the Dead" became most closely associated with the Civil War, as it appeared on both Union and Confederate monuments during the 1860s.

DISCLAIMER

PLEASE UNDERSTAND THAT EVEN THOUGH THIS INFORMATION HAS BEEN TAKEN
FROM WEBSITES & OTHER SOURCES THAT APPEAR TO BE AUTHENTIC, I CAN NOT ENSURE THAT ALL THE
DATA IN THIS ARTICLE IS ACCURATE AND CORRECT